POLS 1 - Introduction to Political Philosophy

Instructor: Kylie Gaines

Summer Session B: August 4th - September 13th
Class Time and Location: Monday - Thursday, 9:30 am - 10:35 am via Zoom

Office Hours: Mondays 11am to 2pm
Instructor Office: Ellison Hall 2814
Instructor Email: kyliegaines@ucsb.edu

Teaching Assistants

TA: **Email:** **Office Location:** **Office Hours:** **Section:**	**TA:** **Email:** **Office Location:** **Office Hours:** **Section:**

Course Description
This course provides an introduction to core themes and texts in political philosophy with an orientation towards describing and understanding distinctions that structure political thought and continue to exert a measurable impact on our world. In particular, this course will examine distinctions between justice/injustice, citizen/slave, human/Man, and freedom/unfreedom, among others. Together, we will examine how canonical political theorists construct these distinctions and form boundaries around the political and how more recent, critical voices expose the exclusionary rhetoric and implications of earlier work.

Hybrid Instruction
This course follows a hybrid format. Lectures will be held synchronously via Zoom, and all students are expected to log in on time and attend the whole session. *Discussion sections will be held in person on campus.*

Required Texts
No textbook needed; all readings will be available via Canvas!

Grade Distribution

- *Two Reflections (7.5% each, totaling 15%):* Students will complete two short reflections, one at the beginning of the course and one at the end. The first reflection will ask you to reflect on your initial thoughts on political theory and what you expect from the course. The second

reflection will ask you to revisit your initial ideas to see if anything has changed in relation to your understanding of course material and political theory in general. Each reflection should be approximately 1-2 pages in length. Full instructions will be provided on Canvas (see below for more information).

- *Two Papers (25% each, totaling 50%): Students will be required* to complete two papers before the end of the session. Each paper is worth 25% of their final grade (with two papers cumulatively accounting for 50% of the final grade). Papers should be 5-6 pages in length. Instructions on the format will be issued along with a series of prompts during the session. Students will be able to select one prompt to answer in essay format. Essays must be uploaded onto Canvas no later than the due date and time. **All papers must be written in Google Docs so that version history can be accessed upon request. You will upload a pdf or word document to Canvas as usual, but should retain the original Google Doc. If concerns about authorship arise, students must be prepared to share version history within 24 hours of request. Papers should also include formal, in-text citations that include author name and page number.** (see below for more information).

- *Two Quizzes (10% each, totaling 20%): There will be a total of two* quizzes, to be taken during the session. Cumulatively, quizzes will count for 20% of your final grade. You will be asked to answer a series of multiple choice questions. These quizzes will be taken during section in weeks three and five. (see below for more information).

- *Section Attendance and Participation (15%):* Consult with your TA for more information.

Assignment Due Dates

- Reflection I (7.5%): Must be uploaded onto the Canvas Course website by Saturday, August 9 (11:59 pm PST).
- Paper 1 (25%): Must be uploaded onto the Canvas course website by Saturday, August 16 (11:59 pm PST).
- Paper 2 (25%): Must be uploaded onto the Canvas course website by Saturday, August 30 (11:59 pm PST).
- Reflection II (7.5%): Must be uploaded onto the Canvas Course website by Saturday, September 13 (11:59 pm PST).
- Quizzes (20%): To be taken in section. Quiz one will be taken in section during week three and quiz two will be taken in section during week five.

Late Work Policy

Barring emergent circumstances, all paper due dates are firm. A *one-hour grace period* will be allowed after the deadline. After that, late papers will incur a 3% grade deduction, with an additional 3% deduction for every twelve hours thereafter.

For Example:

- A paper that earns a 90 and is submitted 2 hours late will receive an 87.
- That same paper submitted 26 hours late will receive an 81.

Quizzes will be taken in section. Barring emergent circumstances, quiz makeups will not be allowed.

Regrade Policy

If you receive a grade that, upon honest self-reflection, you believe deserves a higher score, you may request a reconsideration. To do this, you must submit a one-page written reflection on the comments your TA offered, as well as make a respectful and persuasive case on why you believe your work merits a higher score. Regrade requests must be submitted within one week following the release of grades. *Note*: I reserve the right to adjust your grade up or down based on my assessment of the assignment.

COURSE SCHEDULE

Week One:

- **Monday, August 4th: Welcome and Introduction**
  - *Optional Reading,* Explained: Generative AI's Environmental Impact, https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117
  - *Optional Reading, * Lorde, "Master's Tools will Never Dismantle the Master's House"
- **Tuesday, August 5th: Setting the Stage: Plato's Republic Book One**
  - Plato, *Republic,* S.N. 357a - 376c
- **Wednesday, August 6th: Justice in the City and the Soul**
  - Plato, *Republic,* S.N. 414a - 417b & 419a -445e
- **Thursday, August 7th: The Limits of Platonic Equality**
  - Plato, *Republic,* S.N. 449a-476b & 514a-519d

Reflection I due on Saturday, August 9th at 11:59 pm PST

Week Two:

- **Monday, August 11th: A Slow Slip into Madness: Aristocracy to Tyranny**
  - Plato, *Republic,* S.N. 543a-580c
- **Tuesday, August 12th: Toward Virtue: The Golden Mean**
  - Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics,* Book I and II, pp. 3-32
- **Wednesday, August 13th: Man as Political Animal**
  - Aristotle, *Politics,* Book I, Chapters 1-7 & Book 3, Chapters 6-12
- **Thursday, August 14th: The Coloniality of Being**
  - Wynter, "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom: Towards the Human, After Man, Its Overrepresentation--An Argument," pp. 257-288
  - Robinson, "Slavery and the Platonic Origins of Anti-Democracy"

Paper one due on Saturday, August 16th at 11:59 pm PST

Week Three:

- **Monday, August 18th: Distinction as Method in Classical Antiquity**
    - Aristophanes, Lysistrata
    - Herodotus, *Histories,* 1.131 - 1.140
    - Thucydides, *History of the Peloponnesian War,* The Melian Dialogue

Tuesday, August 19th: The State of Nature is a State of War

- Hobbes, *Leviathan,* pp. 7-8 & 76-102
- **Wednesday, August 20th: "Listen to an Arbitrary Ruler:" A Classic by Thomas Hobbes**
    - Hobbes, *Leviathan,* pp. 103-136
- **Thursday, August 21st: The Sexual Contract**
    - Pateman, *The Sexual Contract,* pp. 1-38

Quiz one to be taken during section

Week Four:

- **Monday, August 25th: The Racial Contract**
    - Mills, "Philosophy and the Racial Contract," pp. 65-74
- **Tuesday, August 26th: On Alienation**
    - Marx, *The Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts,* "Estranged Labor"
- **Wednesday, August 27th: Everything is for Sale: Commodification and the Logic of Capital**
    - Marx and Engels, *The Communist Manifesto,* pp. 3-39
- **Thursday, August 28th: On Racial Capitalism**
    - Robinson, *Black Marxism,* Preface, Introduction, and Chapter One

Paper two due on Saturday, August 30th at 11:59 pm PST

Week Five:

- **Monday, September 1st:**
    - *Labor Day, no lecture – enjoy your day off!*
- **Tuesday, September 2nd: Do we Have an Obligation to Follow the Law?**
    - Plato, Crito
    - Sophocles, Antigone
- **Wednesday, September 3rd: On Being the Gadfly**
    - Thoreau, Henry David, *Resistance to Civil Government,* "Essay on Civil Disobedience"
    - King, Martin Luther, "Letter from Birmingham Jail"
- **Thursday, September 4th: Is Violence ever Justified? Resistance and Revolutionary Action**
    - Fanon, Franz, *Wretched of the Earth,* "Concerning Violence," pp. 35-95
    - X, Malcolm, Ballot or the Bullet Speech

Quiz two to be taken during section

Week Six:

- **Monday, September 8th: Who Constructs Distinctions and Who Wins?**
    - Schmitt, *The Concept of the Political*, pp. 19-37
    - Scott, *Seeing Like a State,* pp. 11-38
    - Foucault, Michel, *Discipline and Punish,* pp. 214-247
- **Tuesday, September 9th: Unlearning Distinction**
    - Lorde, Audre, "Master's Tools will Never Dismantle the Master's House"
    - hooks, bell, "Choosing the Margin as a Space of Radical Openness"
    - Brown, Jayna, *Black Utopias,* "Introduction"
- **Wednesday, September 10th: Wrap up: What have we learned?**
    - *****No reading for today*****
- **Thursday, September 11th:**
    - *No lecture today, please take this time to work on your final reflections.*

Reflection II due on Saturday, September 13 at 11:59 pm PST

Disabled Students Program (DSP)

If you require accommodations, please contact the DSP to register. If you are already registered with DSP, kindly ask them to reach out to me with your accommodation requests so that we can coordinate before your first assignment is due. Since the summer session moves quickly, it's especially important to have your accommodations in place early.

AI Policy

Use of any AI or LLM **is not permitted in this course.** The purpose of a course like this is to help you develop your ability to interpret complex texts as well as think critically and form your own arguments. I know it can be useful and help make tasks easier, but for this course, it is not allowed. Use of Grammarly is acceptable.

Academic Dishonesty

"All members of the academic community share responsibility for the academic integrity of the UCSB community. Academic dishonesty is an assault upon the basic integrity and meaning of a University. Cheating, plagiarism, and collusion in dishonest activities are serious acts which erode the University's educational and research roles and cheapen the learning experience as well as the value of one's degree. This is true for perpetrators as well as the entire community. It is expected that all UCSB students will support the ideal of academic integrity and that they will be responsible for the integrity of their work. ***Materials (written or otherwise) submitted to fulfill academic requirements must represent a student's own efforts unless otherwise permitted by an instructor. It is also the responsibility of each student to know the campus rules regarding academic misconduct—ignorance is no excuse****." (*Academic Integrity at UCSB: A Student's Guide*)

Resources
Mental Health Support: https://caps.sa.ucsb.edu/
If you are food insecure: https://food.ucsb.edu/resources/food-resources
If you are housing insecure: https://food.ucsb.edu/resources/housing
If you are in need of a laptop/tech: https://food.ucsb.edu/resources/technology-resources

If you want or need help accessing these resources, I am always available to help!